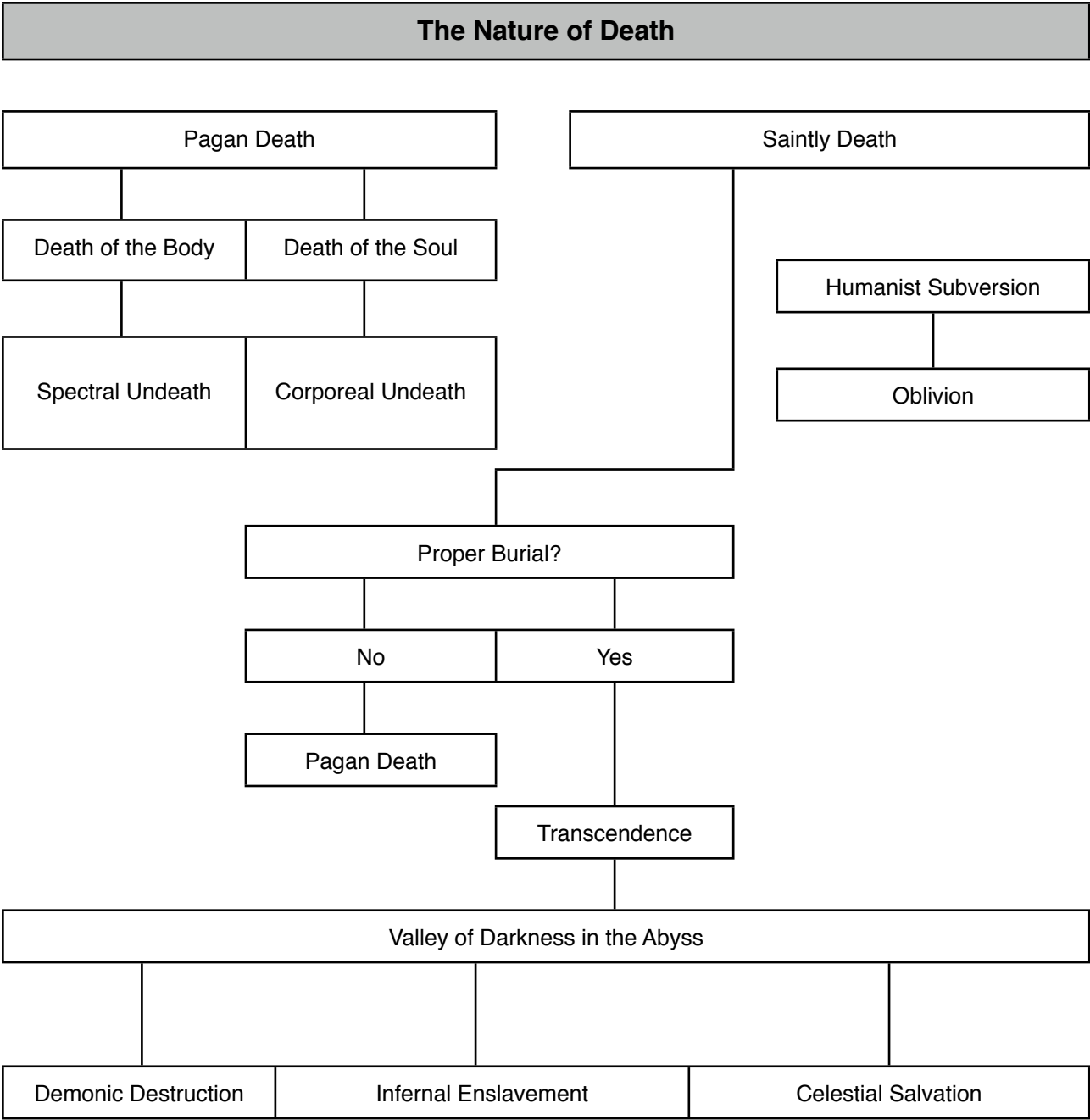




Definitions

Death: the damaging of the corporeal or spectral (or both) essences that together combine to form a living being. As a general rule, it takes Material means to damage the body, and Magical means to damage the soul. However countless techniques have been created throughout the Ages of History that allow both for material means to actively wound the soul, and magical means to wreak great harm upon the body. Curiously, it only seems possible to utilise magical means (either directly through magical spells and incantations, or indirectly through the rare magically empowered artifacts) in order to achieve this. Alchemists theorise that it is possible to use solely mundane material means to damage a soul. Current thought suggests that one must first find pure mundane material that contains no trace of magical energy within its composition in order to achieve this. Unfortunately, given the deep connexion between energy and matter, this mythical mundane substance continues to elude even the most learned alchemists.

Pagan Death: any death that is not Saintly

Death of the Body: a death where the corporeal vessel of the being is damaged beyond its ability to function, but where the Soul manages to survive this event. This type of death leads to the creation of a spectral undead, where the soul remains in the World without its corporeal counterpart. Very powerful

beings can often continue to control their original bodies even in death, creating non-spectral forms of undead that retain the personality and intellectual capacity of the original being.

Death of the Soul: a death where the corporeal vessel remains relatively intact, but where the soul of the being is damaged beyond its ability to exist. This form of death is rather difficult to achieve by material means, as discussed above. However, the abundance of non-spectral undead in the World speak to the ease with which the soul can be eradicated.

Saintly Death: a proper death. that is, the death of a devout and pious practitioner of the Saintly Faith. A proper burial with the correct rites must be undertaken in order to complete the process. It goes without saying that the Soul needs to survive the death, since this is the element of the being which will break through into the Abyss. A Death of the Soul, even for a Saintly Man, will result in a Pagan Death, and will deny the Man his due rewards. Great care must be taken by the Pious Man to preserve the health of his Soul.

Proper Burial: A burial rite as defined in the canons of the church which must be performed before the end of a full day since the being's death. This involves the proper preparation and disposition of the body to prevent its reanimation as a corporeal undead. It also involves the proper rites and incantations performed by an ordained member of the Faith's clergy. Only an authorised clergyman performing the sanctioned rites can open the necessary passage for the Soul to transcend into the Abyss.

Transcendence: the voyage of the Soul from the magical and material World into the Abyss. The exact nature and method of this Act is mysterious by its very nature.

Valley of Darkness: the gateway to the Abyss, located at the very upper edge of the great Pit. It is here that the link between our World and the Abyss is at its strongest and closest. Hence, upon the transcendence of the Soul, this is the geographic place of arrival.

Demonic Destruction: should a Soul enter into the Abyss unprepared and unescorted it will fall prey to the Abyssal demons that dwell there. The demons feast and survive upon the nourishment provided by the Lost Souls of the World.

Infernal Enslavement: the alternative to Demonic Destruction is the possibility of enslavement (both voluntary and involuntary) to the Infernal devils. Voluntary enslavement can come in one of two ways: either the Soul was a practitioner or servant of the Black Faith, who nevertheless received a Proper Burial and transcended as part of his dark bargain, thus fulfilling his contractual obligation of eternal slavery; or the Soul was a Faithful Man who was tempted into slavery upon his arrival at the Valley of Darkness. Why this second choice happens is a matter of great theological debate. Involuntary enslavement is exactly how it sounds: the newly arrived Souls fall prey to the slaving gangs of the Infernals before they can be met and rescued by the Celestial Saints.

Celestial Salvation: eternal peace and tranquility in the infinite safety of Celestia-in-Exilio.

Humanist Subversion: a baseless pseudo-intellectual "philosophy" recently propagated by miscreants and malcontents with too much time on their privileged hands

Oblivion: the alleged result of both the Body and the Soul as explained by the Humanists. Supposedly, upon death the Soul will decompose into the World's energy much like the Body will decompose into the World's matter. This preposterous notion completely ignores the millennia of established canonical evidence to the contrary.